

- RAG Learning

3B.2 Global Governance: Political and Economic

Politics — Edexcel (9PL0) — Component 3B: Global Politics — spec topic 3: Global governance: political and economic

Exam Tip: Component 3 has two routes. This is **3B (Global Politics)**; the alternative is **3A (Comparative Politics: USA)**. You sit one, never both.

This topic covers the institutions that manage international peace, security and the world economy. The recurring analytical question is whether they **constrain** the powerful or merely **reflect** them — which is the realist–liberal dispute in concrete form.

Global governance — managing shared problems through rules and institutions without a world government.

Collective security — a system in which all states commit to respond jointly to aggression by any state against another, as under Chapter VII of the UN Charter. Distinguish **collective**

defence — an alliance pledge that an attack on one member is an attack on all (NATO Article 5).

Veto — the power of each permanent Security Council member to block a substantive resolution.

Conditionality — policy conditions attached to loans.

Structural adjustment — liberalising reforms required of borrowing states.

Washington Consensus — privatisation, deregulation, fiscal discipline and liberalisation as a policy package.

North–South divide — the economic gap between wealthier industrialised states and poorer developing ones.

Dependency theory — underdevelopment caused by poorer states' structural position in a global economy organised around the wealthy core.

Global civil society — NGOs and transnational networks acting across borders.

1. Political governance: the United Nations

Organ	Function	Weakness
Security Council	International peace and security; 15 members, 5 permanent; resolutions can be binding	The P5 veto paralyses it wherever a permanent member's interest is engaged
General Assembly	All members, one vote each; debates, budget, admissions	Resolutions are not binding
ECOSOC	Coordinates economic, social and humanitarian work and the specialised agencies	Limited authority over the agencies in practice
ICJ	Settles legal disputes between states; advisory opinions	Jurisdiction depends on state consent
Secretariat	Administration, headed by the Secretary-General	Depends on member funding and cooperation

The veto

Criticism	Defence
One member can block action however broad the support — Syria, Ukraine	Without it the major powers would not have joined or remained; the League's failure is the warning
Membership reflects 1945, not the present distribution of power — India, Brazil, Japan, Germany and all of Africa lack permanent seats	An organisation excluding the powerful would be weaker still
Undermines legitimacy and therefore compliance	Charter amendment requires P5 consent, so those advantaged hold a veto over changing their own advantage

Peacekeeping

The UN maintains no standing force and depends on member contributions. Mandates are usually limited by the consent required from parties to the conflict, and missions are frequently under-resourced. Successes exist — Namibia, Liberia, Sierra Leone — alongside the failures at Rwanda and Srebrenica that define the institution's reputation.

NATO

A collective defence alliance founded in 1949. **Article 5** provides that an armed attack on one member is an attack on all — invoked once, after 11 September 2001, by the United States, for an alliance designed to protect Europe. It has outlasted the threat it was created to meet by adapting: enlarging eastward, taking on crisis management and counter-terrorism, and finding renewed purpose as great power competition returned.

2. Economic governance

Institution	Role	Criticism
IMF	Monetary stability; lends to states facing balance of payments crises	Weighted voting; conditionality; austerity requirements
World Bank	Long-term development finance — infrastructure, health, education	Weighted voting; project impacts; policy conditions
WTO	Administers trade rules; dispute settlement	Doha deadlock; the Appellate Body paralysed since 2019
G7	Advanced economies; informal coordination	Excludes emerging powers; no binding authority
G20	Includes major emerging economies; coordinated the 2008 crisis response	No binding authority; large and unwieldy

The Bretton Woods critique

- **Weighted voting.** Power is proportional to financial contribution, so wealthy states control institutions lending mainly to poorer ones. By convention the IMF is headed by a European and the World Bank by an American.
- **Structural adjustment.** Liberalising conditions — privatisation, deregulation, devaluation, spending cuts — applied with limited regard to local circumstances, frequently falling on health, education and subsidies.
- **Ideological uniformity.** The Washington Consensus treated one model as universally applicable, despite successful East Asian developers having used extensive state direction of the kind the conditions prohibited.
- **Accountability.** Neither institution answers to the populations affected by its conditions.

The defence: they lend where private markets will not; conditionality is intended to ensure repayment and address the causes of crisis; and both have moderated, giving more weight to poverty reduction and local ownership since around 2000.

The WTO's difficulties

The Doha Round collapsed without agreement: consensus among 160-plus members with divergent interests makes comprehensive new agreements effectively impossible. More seriously, the **Appellate Body** ceased to function when the United States blocked appointments from 2019, so appeals cannot be heard and the binding character of WTO rulings has been substantially undermined. Frustrated states have turned to regional and bilateral deals, fragmenting the system the WTO was created to unify.

This is the strongest single piece of evidence for realism on this paper: the most legalised and enforceable part of global economic governance was disabled by one state withdrawing consent.

3. Development and the North–South divide

Explanation	Claim
Orthodox / modernisation	Underdevelopment reflects insufficient integration, weak institutions and poor governance; the remedy is liberalisation and investment

Dependency theory	Underdevelopment is caused by the structural position of poorer states in a global economy organised around the interests of the wealthy core — the periphery supplies raw materials and cheap labour
World-systems	Core, semi-periphery and periphery; mobility between them is possible but rare

4. Global civil society and non-state actors

- **Agenda-setting** — landmines, debt relief through Jubilee 2000, and climate all advanced through civil society campaigning before governments acted.
- **Expertise** — Amnesty International, Human Rights Watch and the International Crisis Group supply information states lack or will not collect about one another.
- **Monitoring** — documenting violations and publicising non-compliance, which states will not do to each other for diplomatic reasons.
- **Delivery** — humanitarian relief and development programmes, sometimes exceeding official agencies in scale.
- **Criticism** — NGOs are not democratically accountable and are frequently funded by developed-world donors, so their priorities may reflect those donors rather than the populations they claim to represent.

5. Evaluation

Why economic governance has been more effective than security governance: economic institutions have rules, monitoring and dispute settlement backed by material incentives, while security decisions run through a Council where a single veto blocks action. Economic co-operation is also positive-sum, repeated and divisible, so states have ongoing reputational incentives to comply; security questions are frequently zero-sum, concern survival, and arise as one-off crises.

The realist qualification: the WTO's collapse suggests the distinction is less fundamental than it appears. Both work while the strongest states are content; the economic sphere merely took longer to reach the point where they were not.

Quick recall

- UN founded 1945; Security Council 15 members, 5 permanent with a veto; General Assembly one state one vote
- Peacekeeping depends on member contributions and party consent — Namibia and Sierra Leone against Rwanda and Srebrenica
- NATO 1949; Article 5 invoked once, after 9/11
- IMF (stabilisation) / World Bank (development) / WTO (trade rules) — all weighted or consensus-bound
- Washington Consensus; structural adjustment; dependency theory; world-systems
- WTO Appellate Body paralysed since 2019 — the best evidence for realism on this paper
- G7 advanced economies; G20 includes emerging powers, coordinated the 2008 response
- NGOs: agenda-setting, expertise, monitoring, delivery — but not democratically accountable